

International stars to watch

Aashin Prasad

aashin.p@thehindu.co.in



Pics: GETTY IMAGES

MARKUS REHM (Germany)

Rehm, who will be entering his ninth World Championships, will be among the most decorated para athletes on the track. The German long jumper has seven long jump gold medals — three in F44 and four in T64 classifications — in the Championships.

The five-time Paralympic gold medallist is also the current record holder in T64 with a jump of 8.72 metres set in the 2023 edition.

Nicknamed the '*blade jumper*' due to his blade-type leg prosthesis, Rehm had his right leg amputated after a wakeboarding accident at the age of 14.

Rehm attempted to qualify for the 2016 Summer Olympics, but the International Association of Athletics Federations, now known as World Athletics, denied him admission because he failed to prove that his prosthesis would not give him an advantage over able-bodied athletes.

At 37, he is not quite done yet, with Mike Powell's world record long jump of 8.95m still in his sight.

PETRUCIO FERREIRA (Brazil)

The three-time Paralympic champion in the 100m T47 classification will be keen to set the track on fire in New Delhi.

Ferreira lost his arm below the elbow at the age of two in an accident in his father's farm. The Brazilian began competing only in 2013. Barely 18 months into the sport, a 19-year-old Ferreira beat Paralympic and World champion Yohansson Nascimento in the 200m race at the Sao Paulo IPC Athletics Grand Prix while setting a new World record.

He made good on his promise by winning his first World gold in London 2017 in the 100m T47, before adding three more successive titles in 2019, 2023 and 2024. He will once again be the favourite to take home the title of 'sprint king' this year.

The 28-year-old currently holds the world records in the 100m T47 and 200m T47 with timings of 10.29s and 20.83s, respectively, both set on March 31, 2022, in Sao Paulo.

